ORECCHIETTE CON CIME DI RAPA

REGION	SERVES	TOTAL TIME
South	**4-6**	**1 h 30 min plus the dough rest**

INGREDIENTS

228 g	Country bread, half a loaf, torn into pieces
56 g	Olive oil, for the bread crumbs
10 g	Garlic cloves, for the bread crumbs
1 batch	Semolina dough
346 g	Broccoli rabe, one large bunch
42 g	Olive oil
45 g	Garlic, finely chopped
30 g	Oil-packed anchovy fillets, finely chopped
4 g	Dried red chile flakes
110 g	Dry white wine
22 g	Pecorino romano, finely grated

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 200°F for the bread crumbs.
2. Spread the torn bread over a sheet pan and dry it out in the oven, 30 to 45 minutes, without letting it take any color. Crush a shard with the back of a spoon to check — the inside should be completely dry. Let it cool.
3. Pulse the cooled bread in a food processor down to fine crumbs. Stop while they still hold some texture rather than carrying on to dust.
4. Set a saute pan over medium-low heat with the 56 g olive oil and the whole garlic cloves. Cook 1 to 2 minutes, until the garlic has perfumed the oil, then fish the cloves out and keep them for another use.
5. Turn the heat to low and line a plate with paper towels. Add the crumbs and cook, stirring now and then, until golden brown, 5 to 8 minutes. Drain them on the plate and let them cool.
6. Measure out 40 g of the crumbs for this dish. The rest keeps a week in an airtight container somewhere cool and dry.
7. Make 624 g of orecchiette from the semolina dough.
8. Strip the broccoli rabe leaves from the stems. Chop the stems and the florets into very small pieces. Chop the leaves fine and keep them to one side.
9. Salt a large pot of water generously and bring it to the boil.
10. Set a large saute pan over low heat. Add the 42 g olive oil and the chopped garlic and cook gently 10 to 15 seconds, taking no color.
11. Stir in the anchovies, chile flakes and the broccoli rabe stems and florets. Add the wine and about 3 ladles of pasta water, 170 g. Braise 3 to 5 minutes, until tender but still bright green. Add the leaves and give them 1 to 2 minutes, then set the pan aside.
12. Cook the orecchiette 4 to 6 minutes, to al dente.
13. Lift the pasta into the saute pan with a spider or pasta basket and raise the heat to medium. Toss gently 1 to 2 minutes to marry. A splash of pasta water loosens the sauce if it feels tight.
14. Divide into bowls and finish with the bread crumbs and pecorino.

NOTES

Cook the broccoli rabe right down until it collapses into something closer to a ragù alongside the anchovy and garlic. That breakdown is what makes the dish — bitter, saline and rich enough to stand in for meat.
Stems, florets and leaves get chopped and cooked separately. The leaves go in last and need only 1 to 2 minutes.
Dry the bread at 200°F with no color on it, then toast the crumbs separately in garlic oil. Pulse them short so they keep some grit.
No sausage. That arrived with the dish in the United States and the original is complex enough without it.
Broccoli rabe is a cool-weather crop, which sets the season for this one.

SHAPE
Orecchiette

Region: Mostly Puglia; also Calabria, Basilicata, Molise, reaching north into Abruzzo / Rest: 1 to 2 hours at room temperature

METHOD

1. Make semolina dough. Dust a wooden board with a little 00 flour. Line a sheet pan with parchment, then dust the parchment with semolina.
2. Quarter the dough. Work one piece and keep the rest under plastic wrap or a towel.

3. Press the piece into a thick rope by hand. Set the fingertips of both hands together at its midpoint, then roll back and forth while walking your hands apart toward the ends.
4. Keep rolling under light pressure until the rope is about 1/2 inch across, roughly as thick as a Sharpie, and about 18 inches long. Cut it in half and roll the halves separately if it gets too long to handle.
5. Cut the rope into 1/2-inch lengths with a knife or bench scraper. Cut them longer while you are learning, since bigger pieces are easier to shape. Cover the pieces you are not shaping.
6. Hold a butter knife serrated-edge-down with its tip against the edge of a piece at a 30-degree angle, then drag the dough toward you across the board. Lean into it. Semolina dough takes real pressure, and you want the middle of the shape thin. Stopping here gives you a cavatello.
7. Use your first two fingers to pull the dough off the knife and up over your thumb, turning it inside out while your thumb pushes up to form a dome. Work through the rest of the cut pieces.
8. Lay the finished pasta on the sheet pan in a single layer.
9. Repeat from step 3 with the remaining dough.
10. Dry 1 to 2 hours at room temperature, until the pasta stiffens slightly and holds its shape when handled.
11. To hold it, wrap the pan in plastic and refrigerate up to 24 hours.

SHAPING



1 2 3 4

NOTES

Dimensions run 1/2-inch rope, about 18 inches long, cut into 1/2-inch pieces. Finished size ranges from a quarter down to a dime, smallest around Bari.
The tool is the serrated edge of an ordinary butter knife. There are two gestures: the drag, then the flip off the knife tip onto the thumb. The flip is what makes an orecchietta instead of a cavatello, and it is the hardest gesture in the book to get right. Expect hundreds of edible failures first.
Keep the board only lightly floured. Too much flour kills the friction and the drag will not take.
Traditionally a water dough built on semolina, durum wheat flour, grano arso, or a blend of two of the three.
Refrigerator limit is 24 hours.
Sauced with tomato and ricotta salata, or with broccoli rabe cooked down with garlic and anchovy.

DOUGH

Semolina Dough

Makes: 750 g / Active Time: 10-15 min kneading / Rest: 30 min minimum, wrapped

INGREDIENTS

325 g	Tipo 00 flour
175 g	Semolina flour
250 g	Lukewarm water
up to 1 tbsp, only if dry	Room-temperature water

METHOD

1. Stir the two flours together thoroughly, then mound on a wooden surface with a well 5 to 6 inches across.
2. Add the water slowly. Water has no body of its own, so it escapes far more easily than yolks do.
3. Draw in flour from the inner wall with a fork as you pour, working round the circumference until all the water is in.
4. Knead 10 to 15 minutes, pressing down and away, rotating, folding.
5. Add water by the tablespoon only if it stays dry.
6. Wrap and rest at least 30 minutes.

NOTES

Eggless, so it stays more elastic and less tender than egg dough. Do not expect the Play-Doh feel here.
50% hydration against 500 g total flour.
65% of the flour is 00 and 35% semolina.
Keeps 24 hours. Chilled overnight, pull it out 20 minutes before rolling.